INTERVIEW

"Blind men see too many elephants"



VIVEK R NAIR

Veteran filmmaker ADOOR GOPALAKRISHNAN *is a colossus of Indian cinema who, over the past five decades, has also been a cultural ambassador of sorts for his home state Kerala. During this time, the 81-year-old auteur has made 12 features, which include world-renowned gems such as* Elipathayam *(The Rat Trap) and* Vidheyan *(The Servile), and some 30 documentaries. He has won the National Film Award 16 times and was awarded the Padma Vibhushan in 2006. Adoor resigned on January 31 as chairman of the K.R. Narayanan National Institute of Visual Science and Arts, Kottayam. This was a corollary to the resignation of Shankar Mohan, a reputed filmmaker and administrator who resigned from his position as director of the institute following student protests and allegations of caste discrimination. Adoor talked to* **Jeemon Jacob** *about the circumstances that led to his exit. Excerpts:*

Q. What prompted you to quit as chairman of the K.R. Narayanan national institute in Kottayam?

Adoor: What else could I have done, I had to save my honour. I tendered my resignation with a five-page letter to the chief minister explaining the reasons. Never in my life have I been accused of being a casteist. I defended Shankar Mohan as I'm aware of the intrigues behind the student protests. I was instrumental in inviting Shankar to lead the institute three years ago. He had a vision and he has made significant contributions in improving academic quality and discipline at the institute. A section of the academic and administrative staff have conspired against him and instigated the students to go on strike. Later, they raised the issue of discrimination against Dalits against him. The allegations raised by a clerical staff were found to be untrue by the SC/ST Commission. Shankar was sincere and had worked wholeheartedly for the past three years to develop the institute. There was a motivated mudslinging campaign and he was humiliated. It set a bad precedent and destroyed the institute's reputation. Under the circumstances, I felt it best that I step down.

Q. Your track record and reputation could have helped the K.R. Narayanan Institute become one of the best film institutes in the country. Do you think this was an unfortunate episode, that the situation could have been averted?

A. Who cares? When some people take it to heart to destroy an institution, such lofty illusions have no place. I am not an unknown entity in Kerala. I have remained secular in my outlook and my work throughout my life and have raised my voice whenever I felt hurt by the actions and declarations of the authorities. Dissonant voices must also be a vital ingredient in the functioning of a democracy. I have never craved for positions or rewards. I raise my voice as it is my conscience speaking. It's for the government to decide the future of the institute now. No institute creates a reputation with mediocre people helming it. Politics is the last thing that should be brought into an educational institution.

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Q. Do you think political interference is a threat to the cultural world?

A. It's not a new phenomenon. When